

DESCRIPTION OF A NEW SPECIES, *POLYPOCEPHALUS KUHLLII* N. SP. (LECANICEPHALIDEA: POLYPOCEPHALIDAE) FROM *DASYATIS KUHLLII* (MULLER & HENLE) FROM VISAKHAPATNAM COAST, BAY OF BENGAL, INDIA

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ABSTRACT: A new species, *Polypocephalus kuhllii* is described from the spiral valve of blue-spotted stingray, *Dasyatis Kuhllii* (Müller & Henle) from the Visakhapatnam coast, Bay of Bengal. *Polypocephalus kuhllii* sp. nov varies from other species in having pear-shaped scolex, acraspedote proglottids, finger-like tentacles, six testes, shape and arrangement of testes, size, shape and position of cirrus sac and host.

Keywords: acraspedote proglottids, cirrus sac, *Dasyatis kuhllii*, *Polypocephalus kuhllii*, scolex, testes.

INTRODUCTION

Lecanicephalid cestodes constitute an important group of cestodes infecting elasmobranchs, in particular rays and sharks. Rays of the genus *Dasyatis* constitute an important food fishery of the East coast of India of which blue-spotted stingray, *Dasyatis Kuhllii* (Müller & Henle) is of abundant occurrence at this coast and offers a suitable habitat to diversified cestode parasitic fauna, in particular tetraphyllids, lecanicephalids and trypanorhynchids. Lecanicephalids predominate the cestode parasitic fauna in this host fish. However, *Polypocephalus* is mostly reported from skates and an only a few reports are from the rays. In the present paper, *Polypocephalus kuhllii* n.sp from *D.kuhllii* has been described following Yamaguti (1959), Schmidt (1986) and Khalil *et al* (1994) were followed for the identification of the genus.

METHODOLOGY

In a survey of cestode parasites from Elasmobranchs at Visakhapatnam coast, about 200 *Dasyatis Kuhllii* (Müller & Henle) were

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